STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



ROLE

THE MANAGER AS COACH

What coaching by a manager is and is not, what the research can and cannot show, and how a short weekly conversation can carry it.

16% of nearly 15,000 employees said the last conversation with their manager was extremely meaningful.

GALLUP, 2023

INSIDE

COVER STORY
From boss to coach
PAGE 03

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS
What coaching changes
PAGE 06

TOOL OF THE ISSUE
The GROW card
PAGE 08

NO. 11 · ROLE

In this issue

Being a good coach comes first on Google's list of what its best managers do, and Gallup calls the change every manager has to make “from boss to coach”. What that looks like in a normal week is the question here.

Gallup finds that few conversations with a manager feel meaningful, and that short weekly ones count more than long rare ones. Google teaches its managers four questions, known as GROW. Two meta-analyses show that coaching at work has clear effects, but they leave out the manager who coaches their own team. That part of the evidence is still to be written, and every manager can add a line to it.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

03 COVER STORY
From boss to coach

04 THE NUMBERS
The conversation that counts

05 THE MODEL
Four questions

06 WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS
What coaching changes

07 HOW IT IS MEASURED
Fifteen minutes a week

08 TOOL OF THE ISSUE
The GROW card

09 SOURCES
Sources and method

HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

From boss to coach

When Google studied what its best managers do, being a good coach came first on the list. Google writes that it was one of the most important behaviours of its highest-scoring managers.

In 2019 Gallup's Jim Clifton and Jim Harter called the change “from boss to coach”. In Google's and Gallup's guidance, coaching takes the form of a short, regular conversation rather than one more task beside the job: the manager often asks more than they tell, and the person chooses the next step.

The boss	The coach
Gives the answer	Asks the question
Checks the result at the end	Talks briefly, every week
Talks about what went wrong	Starts from recent work and strengths

1992
Coaching for Performance makes the GROW model known.

2016
Meta-analysis: coaching at work has clear effects.

2019
Gallup: the manager moves from boss to coach.

2023
Gallup: one meaningful conversation a week.

OUR READING

A boss gives the answer. A coach asks the question that lets the person find it, and then holds them to it.

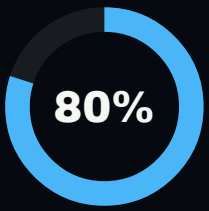
Sources: Google re:Work, 2025; Google re:Work, 2026; Jim Clifton & Jim Harter, Gallup Press, 2019; John Whitmore, 1992 (via Secondary accounts of the GROW model); Rebecca J. Jones, Stephen A. Woods & Yves R. F. Guillaume, Journal of Occupational and Organizational Psychology, 2016; Gallup, 2023

The comparison is our summary of Google's and Gallup's guidance.

THE NUMBERS

The conversation that counts

Gallup asked nearly 15,000 employees about the last conversation with their manager. Only 16% called it extremely meaningful.



of employees who received meaningful feedback in the past week are fully engaged.

In Gallup's findings, conversations of 15 to 30 minutes have more impact than conversations of 30 to 60, if they happen every week. A manager who skips weeks needs longer conversations to catch up.

WHAT MAKES A CONVERSATION MEANINGFUL: GALLUP'S FIRST TWO

01	**Recognition**	for recent work
02	**Collaboration**	and relationships in the team

Goals and priorities, and the person's strengths, are also on the list. Weaknesses are seen as less meaningful, perhaps because in many conversations they are the only topic.

OUR READING

Short and every week beats long and rare. The conversation does not need a meeting room; it needs a fixed place in the week.

Source: Gallup, 2023

THE MODEL

Four questions

GROW became known through John Whitmore's Coaching for Performance in 1992. Google uses it to teach its managers coaching conversations and calls it a simple framework developed in the United Kingdom.

01	02	03	04
Goal	**Reality**	**Options**	**Will**
What do you want?	What is happening now?	What could you do?	What will you do?

Google's guide says GROW works best when the person wants coaching and chooses the topic. The manager asks open questions, listens, and knows when to stop advising so the person chooses the next step: less the one who fixes, more the one who makes it easier.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A SHIFT LEAD AND A NEW TEAM MEMBER

Goal	To close the shift on time
Reality	Two of the last five shifts ran 40 minutes over
Options	Start the handover earlier, ask for help sooner, prepare the counts in the quiet hour
Will	Counts at 20:00, for two weeks

The manager asked; the person chose. The example is invented.

OUR READING

The hardest question for a manager is not one of the four. It is the silence after the third one, when the answer is on the tip of your tongue.

Sources: John Whitmore, 1992 (via Secondary accounts of the GROW model); Google re:Work, 2026

The questions are Google's (re:Work); the translation is ours.

More in the essay How to talk to someone who made a mistake

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

What coaching changes

Two meta-analyses bring together the quantitative studies of coaching at work. Both find clear positive effects, and both leave out the manager who coaches their own team.

EFFECT OF WORKPLACE COACHING, 17 STUDIES (Δ)



Jones, Woods and Guillaume (2016) left out coaching by the manager and by peers, and found stronger effects with internal than with external coaches. Theeboom, Beersma and van Vianen (2014, 18 studies) found effects from g = 0.43 to 0.74, with trained coaches who had no formal authority over the person.

OUR READING

For the manager as coach, the best evidence is still mostly correlation: Gallup's surveys and Google's own data. That is a reason to measure your own team, not a reason to stop.

Sources: Rebecca J. Jones, Stephen A. Woods & Yves R. F. Guillaume, Journal of Occupational and Organizational Psychology, 2016; Tim Theeboom, Bianca Beersma & Annelies E. M. van Vianen, Journal of Positive Psychology, 2014

δ and g are effect sizes; by the usual convention 0.2 is small, 0.5 medium and 0.8 large.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Fifteen minutes a week

Gallup describes five coaching conversations, from a few minutes to a review that looks back and ahead. The weekly one decides whether the others work.

01	**Role and relationship**	expectations and how you work together, at the start and when the role changes
02	**Quick connect**	a few minutes, every week
03	**Check-in**	a longer look at progress and obstacles
04	**Developmental coaching**	around a project or an event
05	**Progress review**	looking back and ahead, a few times a year

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A TEAM OF EIGHT

Team	8 people
Weekly conversation	20 minutes per person
Total	2 h 40 min a week

About the length of one long meeting. (Invented numbers.)

OUR READING

Fifteen minutes is not much time. Fifty weeks of fifteen minutes is a working relationship.

Sources: Gallup, 2020; Gallup, 2023

The names of the five conversations are Gallup's; the descriptions are our summary. The example is the editors'.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The GROW card

One card for one conversation. The person chooses the topic; you ask the four questions and write down only what they decide.

01 Topic chosen by the person

02 Goal what do you want?

03 Reality what is happening now?

04 Options what could you do?

05 Will what will you do, and by when?

06 Next conversation date

Proposed by the editors, using Google's GROW questions. The card belongs to the person, not to a file.

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Following the data: The research behind great managers
Google re:Work, 2025
https://rework.withgoogle.com/intl/en/guides/following-the-data-the-research-behind-great-managers

Coach using the GROW model
Google re:Work, 2026
https://rework.withgoogle.com/intl/en/guides/coach-using-the-grow-model

Coaching for Performance
John Whitmore, 1992 · via Secondary accounts of the GROW model

It's the Manager: Moving From Boss to Coach
Jim Clifton & Jim Harter, Gallup Press, 2019
https://www.gallup.com/itsthemanager/

A Great Manager's Most Important Habit
Gallup, 2023
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/505370/great-manager-important-habit.aspx

The effectiveness of workplace coaching: a meta-analysis of learning and performance outcomes from coaching
Rebecca J. Jones, Stephen A. Woods & Yves R. F. Guillaume, Journal of Occupational and Organizational Psychology, 2016
https://doi.org/10.1111/joop.12119

Does coaching work? A meta-analysis on the effects of coaching on individual level outcomes in an organizational context
Tim Theeboom, Bianca Beersma & Annelies E. M. van Vianen, Journal of Positive Psychology, 2014
https://doi.org/10.1080/17439760.2013.837499

5 Coaching Conversations (Called to Coach)
Gallup, 2020
https://www.gallup.com/cliftonstrengths/en/296192/coaching-conversations-role-relationship-orientation.aspx

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

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